would share such an interest. Moreover, the US had to keep in mind that, in the long term, two competing factors would be at play:

> The US on the one hand shares with Pakistan and China an interest in curbing India's power insofar as it is seen as enhancing the global position of the USSR. On the other hand, the US also has an interest in maintaining influence of its own in India. India is an emerging middle level power bent on and capable of playing a pre-dominant regional role and establishing a strongly competitive position throughout Asia.

At that point, however, Nixon and Kissinger's sensitivities regarding China took precedence. NSC staffers asserted "the new US relationship with China requires that the US not appear to forsake Pakistan or reward India for its recent aggression."[233]

The China imperative called for delaying a response to India's brief overture and any further steps until after Nixon's scheduled visit to China in February. Kissinger was adamant that, given the president's upcoming trip to China in February, it was not the time for the US to respond positively. The US could "not do much now before we go to China because the Chinese are psychopathic." Nixon agreed, but noted that the US should move toward improvement before the elections "for American consumption." Kissinger assured the president that "by July we will have them improved." For domestic consumption, Nixon and Kissinger decided to leak the information that India was seeking an improvement so that they would not get blamed for "driv[ing] them toward the Soviets."[234] Kissinger noted that the choice was whether to normalize relations with India rapidly or "let India work its way back slowly."

The administration agreed on a "go slow" approach until the end of February, letting India take the initiative and keeping up the pressure on it to see "what benefits we can get out of it." The White House decided to dissuade Robert McNamara, then head of the World Bank, from making any new commitment to India in February—that would be, according to Kissinger, "the worst possible time for us to have to face the issue."[235] Any improvement in relations with India had to wait because "we must go to